political contacts, arms smugglers, journalists and powerful media barons. There was no absolute estimate of funds flowing into their kitty but Shekhawat admitted that the band never faced a financial crunch.

The Indian spies had spent almost three months in Australia and New Zealand, gathering support for Fiji's ethnic Indians. Malik returned to Delhi in late August 1988. He had been informed by a source that Rabuka was working on a new constitution for Fiji. He sought a three-month extension for the team to finish the tasks they were working on.

'The extension was granted. But Malik was warned that the situation in the islands was going out of control and wealthy Indians were leaving Fiji. Those in government services were being removed and farmers were charged exorbitant prices for the lease of agricultural land. Malik acknowledged the perils of living under a dictator but his team was trying to do all they could with accuracy/ Shekhawat said. He vividly remembered handing extra packets of freshly minted dollars to Malik. The operation was indeed off the book.

Upon his return to Sydney, Malik accessed the draft of the new Fiji constitution through a contact. The new constitution did not permit Indians to vote and curtailed other fundamental rights. It was horrifying. He sent a copy to New Delhi to generate international diplomatic pressure on Rabuka. The deposed prime minister Timoci Bavadra had already issued a statement which pointed out that the new constitution reduced the Indian people to third class citizenry in a country where they comprised almost fifty per cent of the population. Malik wanted the government of India to release a public statement